

THE REBUILDING Naidu inspects work on the capital project from the MLA/MLC quarters, Aug. 13

THE RESUSCITATION OF AMARAVATI

Chandrababu Naidu's dream capital is racing towards a 2028 deadline, amid rising costs, construction challenges and Jagan Mohan Reddy's rival plan

By **PRASAD NICHENAMETLA** *in Amaravati*

Rains have been a concern this year in agriculture-intensive Andhra Pradesh. Seated in the five-block Interim Secretariat Complex at Velagapudi, a G+1 structure from where the state has been administered since 2016 after the set-up shifted from Hyderabad following Andhra's bifurcation in 2014, chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu—fond of review meetings—is directing officials to extend all possible support to farmers to mitigate the El Niño-induced drought conditions.

But farmers in the vicinity—from the 29 villages and revenue lands constituting the Amaravati capital area—are not exactly worried about their crop. "Rains are a disruption to construction activity," says Sambasiva Rao Upputuri, a farmer from Thulluru village. For the past decade, the fields along the Krishna (on the other side of which is Vijayawada) have been yielding gigantic buildings, not the 2-3 crops sown earlier each year. Sambasiva was among 29,966 Guntur farmers who gave up 34,400 acres in 2015-16 for Naidu's grand vision of Amaravati, the new capital he conceived of in his earlier term after losing Hyderabad to Telangana. It was, as Naidu claims, "the largest land pooling exercise in the world", one that the "World Bank presented as a case study".

"We want the project to be finished at the earliest," says Sambasiva, who gave up his one acre in the hope that, like thousands of others, he too would get a developed 250-450 square yard (sq. yd) commercial and 1,000 sq. yd residential plot in return. The pooling scheme also promised an annuity to compensate for the loss of farm income, but locals also expected high-income